

Tips & Tricks

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QnA

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Digging into Firefox 4

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Six years ago, Firefox 1.0 was released by Mozilla Corporation and that started the browser war. Today, Firefox commands approximately 25 per cent market share and the love of every single geek in the world. With the launch of Firefox 4, they are challenging the limits of what a browser can do and further erasing the boundaries between a web app and a Desktop app. Let us see what are some of these features are and how you can enable and use them.

Installing Firefox 4

Though the final release is supposed to be released in November 2010, the beta is already out and you can give it a spin by downloading it from www.mozilla.com/



Download Firefox 4 Beta, OS is auto selected

en-US/firefox/all-beta.html. If you install the beta, it will not remove your existing installation, but will use your settings so your bookmarks and extensions will be automatically accessible in Firefox Beta 4. You can launch your current version or the Beta 4 by selecting it from the Start Menu, albeit only one at a time. As a friendly reminder, we would like to tell you that a lot of your add-ons might not work.

Enabling hardware acceleration Direct2D (only for Windows)

Direct2D is a 2D and vector graphics API designed by, and for, Microsoft. It improves performance and quality by taking advantage of hardware acceleration if you have a graphics card/drivers that support it.

Unfortunately, it is not switched on by default in the Firefox 4 Beta since the developers didn't want to regress any functionality in the browser for majority of their users, so by default, DirectWrite would have been selected.

A handytip at this point is that if you're running the aero interface in Windows 7/ Vista or the Compiz Windows Manager in Linux, you have hardware acceleration enabled on your system. To enable it in your browser, here is what you have to

do. But before you proceed any further, note your experience/frame rates while rotating/resizing the photographs in that link, you would need to know this to confirm if you have enabled Direct2D.

- Open Firefox 4 Beta and in a new tab, type `about:config` in the address bar and press [Enter].
- Taste the humour of Firefox developers and approve of the warning.
- Enter `render` in the Filter box.
- Double-click on `gfx.font_rendering.directwrite.enabled` to set it to `True`.
- Double-click on `mozilla.widget.render-mode`, and set the value to `6`.
- Restart Firefox. You don't need to restart the system.

Now again, go back to the link above after restarting the browser. If you notice an improvement, things are great and you will slowly start noticing an improvement in your browser experience especially on graphics heavy sites.

In case you don't, here is a small list of things that could have gone wrong:

If you have Windows XP, then it doesn't support Direct2D, so you need to upgrade to Windows 7 / Vista. If you have an extension that is interfering with Direct2D, try disabling it. It's likely that your system/graphics card/driver doesn't support hardware acceleration. You can check this using Aero/Compiz.

By setting `webgl.software_render` to `True` for Linux installation will help a bit in your browsing experience.

WebGL

Why stop at 2D hardware acceleration when you can have 3D. Now we will enable WebGL in our browsers. If you don't know what WebGL is, don't panic. This is a method of accessing OpenGL from within the browser via HTML5. Mozilla has been working on this for quite a while now via experiments under the hood of Canvas3D. Currently, the effort is spearheaded by the Khronos Group. To enable it:

1. Open Firefox 4 Beta. In a new tab, type `about:config` in the address bar and press [Enter].
2. Enter `webgl` in the Filter box.
3. Double-click on `webgl.enabled_for_`